

Open Innovation and Value Co-creation in Digital Platforms: A Case Study of Taobao

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Taobao's evolution from a search-driven online marketplace into a content-rich, community-oriented consumption ecosystem represents one of the most consequential strategic transformations in China's platform economy. This essay critically examines Taobao's open innovation and co-creation strategy through the theoretical lenses of Chesbrough's (2020) open innovation framework and Vargo and Lusch's (2016) service-dominant logic. Taobao has gained distinctive competitive advantages by systematically engaging external stakeholders, including content creators, creative merchants, and core brand communities, in value co-creation. Yet the central argument is that this very strategy has simultaneously introduced deep-seated governance tensions and structural dependencies that challenge the platform's long-term resilience. The analysis first identifies the catalysts that compelled Taobao toward open innovation. It then examines three progressively deeper layers of stakeholder collaboration, namely Taobao Live, the Taobao Maker Festival, and the Golden Taobao Awards, analyzing each alongside its inherent tensions. Finally, it evaluates the strategic trade-offs of this transformation and reflects on broader implications for platform-based co-creation.

In the early 2010s, Taobao had firmly established itself as China's dominant online marketplace, operating on a relatively straightforward platform logic that simply connected buyers and sellers. By the mid-2010s, however, a confluence of external competitive pressure, internal structural limitations, and shifting consumer expectations began to expose this traditional e-commerce model's fundamental vulnerabilities, compelling Taobao to embrace open innovation and co-creation strategies (Chesbrough, 2003).

The first source of pressure was the intensification of external competition and the resulting erosion of user engagement. The emergence of Pinduoduo in 2015 introduced a social commerce model that integrated group-buying mechanics with WeChat's social network, embedding shopping into a socially driven purchase journey (Yang, 2019). More critically, the rise of short video and livestreaming

platforms such as Douyin fundamentally altered consumer attention. These platforms did not merely compete for transaction share; they transformed online shopping from a utilitarian, search-driven activity into an entertainment-driven, discovery-oriented experience (Ma et al., 2024; Wang, 2025). In this new attention economy, Taobao found itself structurally disadvantaged, because its core user experience was designed for efficient purchase completion rather than for sustained browsing and content consumption (Evans & Schmalensee, 2016).

The second catalyst lay in the inherent limitations of Taobao's transactional marketplace model. As a two-sided platform, Taobao had long optimized for matching efficiency, connecting buyer intent with seller inventory at scale. This architecture, however, fostered shallow, episodic relationships between buyers and sellers. Small and medium-sized merchants found it difficult to accumulate loyal customers, while price competition eroded their margins and inhibited the organic cultivation of brand equity (Teece, 2010). The platform's value proposition increasingly degenerated into a mere traffic arbitrage mechanism, which was neither sustainable for merchants nor differentiating for Taobao itself.

At the same time, a new generation of Chinese consumers began to demand more than transactional efficiency. Their consumption journeys centered increasingly on discovery, curation, and social validation (Biggs et al., 2017; Luo et al., 2025; Zhang & Rosli, 2025). Shopping was no longer solely about acquiring goods; it had become intertwined with identity expression, community participation, and entertainment.

These were precisely the qualities that Taobao's experience lacked at the time.

Taobao's initial responses to these pressures focused on price-driven incentives such as "Taobao Coins." While these tools could generate short-term spikes in activity, they failed to address the deeper structural deficit: the platform could not solve its engagement and innovation challenges solely through internal resources. In essence, the traditional boundaries of the firm had become a constraint on Taobao's ability to adapt (Wang, 2019).

In summary, these converging pressures collectively created a strategic imperative for Taobao to open its organizational boundaries, invite external actors into the value creation process, and fundamentally reimagine its role from a transaction marketplace to an ecosystem that orchestrates co-creation.

Taobao's transition toward an open innovation paradigm was not a singular move but an all-round process that deepened the scope of stakeholder collaboration. Unfolding across three interlocking layers, from the co-production of the consumption experience, through the co-definition of products, to the co-construction of community identity. For a two-sided platform, Taobao fundamental redefine its role, becoming an orchestrator of values co-creation among multiple interdependent stakeholder groups (Tiwana, 2014). Zhang et al (2024) further confirms that digital technologies are shifting value creation from firm-centric processes toward multi-actor interactions within innovation ecosystems, with platforms serving as the paradigmatic organizational form of this transformation. Yet this orchestration, as the following analysis will demonstrate which simultaneously generates tensions that challenge the very ecosystem it seeks to build.

The most visible entry point for Taobao's co-creation strategy is Taobao Live, which reconfigures consumer consumption journey. It represents a triadic architecture in which the platform provides technological infrastructure and algorithmic traffic distribution, content creators contribute trust and emotional labor, and consumers participate in shaping the consumption scenario through real-time interaction. The central tenet of service-dominant logic that value is co-created through multi-actor interactions rather than delivered unidirectionally finds vivid empirical illustration here (Vargo & lush, 2016). The streaming technology itself offers streamers real-time insights into audience behavior, and the integrated payment and logistics systems that ensure frictionless transaction completion (Prince Clement Addo et al., 2021).

Crucially, the platform does not produce content itself, it creates the conditions under

which content can be co-produced by other. The streamer acts as a bridging between seller and buyer, converting personal credibility into purchase confidence (Yang and Koh, 2025; Xu, 2022)



Figure 1 Celebrity Live-Streaming

Besides, consumers, through comments, likes and purchase behavior, continuously influence the trajectory of each livestream, while their behavior data feeds back into platform algorithms and merchants' product decision. (Xu, 2022). Value is not embedded in products and delivered to consumers (Zhang and Xu, 2024; Liang, 2025); it is co-created through the interactions among platform, streamer, and audience in a shared experience environment (Azad Moghddam and Mortimer, 2026).

However, this triadic arrangement conceals a fundamental power asymmetry. The trust that streamers cultivate with their audiences causes influence to accumulate disproportionately among top performers. When a small cohort of key opinion leaders commands the attention of millions, they amass substantial bargaining power over both brands and the platform. The recurrent phenomenon of "lowest price on the internet" demands exemplify this dynamic, compelling brand to compress their margins in exchange for access to a streamer's audience. For the platform, this

generates a structural tension: the same creators who drive user engagement and transaction volume simultaneously threaten ecosystem health and the platform's own governance authority (Jia, 2023). The co-creation of the consumption experience is therefore simultaneously empowering and destabilizing.

This concentration of power engenders a cascading governance challenge. When top streamers wield such influence that their departure or a scandal can measurably affect aggregate transaction volume, the platform becomes structurally dependent on the very actors whose power it seeks to contain. The high-profile tax evasion cases involving leading Taobao live streamers in 2021 laid bare this vulnerability: the platform was compelled to sanction its most valuable content creators, absorbing the reputational damage and transaction-volume disruption that ensued. Scholarship on hybrid platform governance conceptualizes this as a paradigmatic tension between market-driven openness and the imperative of regulatory control, wherein platforms must constantly recalibrate the boundary between enabling external innovation and preserving ecosystem stability (Zhang et al., 2026). Consequently, the platform finds itself locked in a state of strategic ambivalence toward its own co-creation partners.

Moving beyond the experiential layer, Taobao extended its co-creation logic into the definition of products themselves through the Taobao Maker Festival. Launched in 2016, this annual event invites the platform's most inventive merchants to showcase experimental products directly to consumers, who function as lead users and co-definers of new product, embodying the outside-in knowledge flow of open innovation (Chesbrough, 2003) and a contemporary manifestation of the "Prosumer" blurring of producer-consumer boundaries (Rizer & Jurgenson, 2010). Examples from past festivals illustrate the boundary -pushing, pet milk tea, culturally reimagined traditional crafts and so on. The Maker Festival marks a deliberate shift from merely connecting supply and demand to cultivating new supply and shaping emerging demand—an 'innovation field' where the platform no longer just asks what

consumers want but invites them to explore alongside creators. Crucially, it serves as a strategic bridge: the moment Taobao began treating its most creative merchants as partners worth investing in and celebrating, transforming the merchant-platform relationship from transactional to collaborative, and laying the foundation for deeper, identity-based co-creation.



Figure 2 Past Photo in Maker Festival

Yet beneath the celebration of grassroots creativity lies a less egalitarian reality of selective participation. The Maker Festival privileges merchants who already command the creative resources, design skills, and niche appeal necessary to be recognized as “Makers.” For most sellers, who lack the capacity for creative experimentation, the festival functions not as an opportunity but as a spectacle from which they are effectively excluded. The platform’s rhetorical pivot from transaction venue to innovation field, though framed as inclusive, inadvertently produces a two-tier ecosystem: celebrated creative partners on one level and invisible commodity suppliers on another. Platform-governance research suggests that the same

institutional arrangements are perceived differently depending on participants' status and resource endowments, leading to an uneven willingness to engage in co-creation (Xiao and Ke, 2024). Crucially, this disparity is not merely a matter of perception; it is structurally embedded in the festival's operating logic. Participation demands precisely the resources that ordinary small sellers lack—design capabilities to conceive experimental products, production flexibility to execute small-batch innovations, and the narrative skills to present these goods compellingly to live audiences. These resources correlate strongly with pre-existing commercial success, generating a self-reinforcing cycle in which the platform's innovation investments flow disproportionately to those already best positioned to innovate. From an open innovation standpoint, this represents a narrowing rather than a broadening of the platform's knowledge base: the ideas tested and amplified through the Maker Festival are drawn from a thin segment of the merchant population, while the tacit knowledge embedded in the vast community of ordinary sellers remains largely untapped (Chesbrough, 2006). The rhetoric of democratized innovation thus masks a reality of concentrated creative opportunity.

The deepest and most subtle layer of Taobao's co-creation architecture finds expression in the Golden Taobao Awards and its accompanying Merchant Sports Festival. In this annual carnival, brands over one million annual sales on the platform receive the Golden Taobao trophy and participate in a whimsical sports competition where giant anthropomorphic plush mascots compete in playful athletic events. The event is filmed and released as online video content that consistently achieves high viewership, which can partly be explained by its knowing embrace of contemporary internet culture and viral memes (Yang, 2022) as well as the resonate with them (Vardeman, 2024).



Figure 3 Screenshot about Golden Taobao Award

On the surface, the Golden Taobao Awards and its accompanying sport festival function as a cross-brands promotional spectacle, generating mutual visibility for the participating brands and the platform alike. However, merely interpret this as a marketing event would overlook the deeper co-creative dynamic at work.

Firstly, the Golden Taobao Awards deploys systematic brand anthropomorphism to create emotional bonds between consumers and brands. Research demonstrates that brand anthropomorphism significantly enhances purchase intentions and brand liking by transferring interpersonal relationship schemas onto consumer-brand interactions (Han et al., 2023). By representing brands as outsized, endearingly clumsy plush characters, the platform shortens the psychological distance between consumers and corporate entities.

At the deepest level, the Golden Taobao Awards co-creates community identity and social capital. By defining the invitation threshold through a concrete commercial metric, the Awards simultaneously enact recognition of achievement and the drawing of a community boundary, communicating that awardees are not merely transactional actors but recognized members of a core community. Empirical research confirms that online social interactions within brand communities contribute to the formation of

"brand social capital"—a distinct construct encompassing the structural, relational and cognitive resources that accrue to community participants (Hoda, 2023; Zarei et al., 2024). From a platform governance perspective, this functions as an investment in soft governance, introducing a relational dimension where identification and belonging become more profound behavioural drivers than contractual enforcement. However, it is precisely at this deepest layer of co-creation that a subtle fissure appears. A curated core community, defined by commercial performance criteria, necessarily entails an act of exclusion. For the small and medium-sized sellers who constitute the bulk of Taobao's merchant base, the Golden Taobao Awards and its associated sports festival represent not an invitation but a distant spectacle of an elite club from which they are effectively barred. What serves as a source of cohesion and identification for the platform's core partners may thus be read by the broader periphery as a marker of internal ecosystem stratification. The impact of platform governance mechanisms on users' willingness to participate in value co-creation is not uniformly distributed: participants with different statuses and resource endowments often develop markedly different perceptions of, and responses to, the same institutional rules (Ke and Xiao, 2025). An intrinsic tension between elite co-creation and the platform's inclusive empowerment narrative thus becomes a fundamental dilemma that Taobao's co-creation strategy must confront.

Compounding this exclusionary dynamic is a deeper vulnerability embedded in the ritual co-creation strategy itself: the very emotional intensity that makes community rituals effective also renders them fragile. When core merchants repeatedly invest their identity in the "Taobao ecosystem member" label through ritual participation, their expectations of the platform shift from transactional fairness to relational reciprocity. A rule change that a purely transactional seller might accept as a commercial adjustment can be experienced as a betrayal by a community member who has internalized the identity narrative. Under conditions of perceived platform

disloyalty, the social capital painstakingly accumulated through the Golden Taobao Awards can thus transform from an asset into a liability—a reservoir of collective grievance rather than collective resilience. This suggests that the soft governance achieved through ritual co-creation is not a stable equilibrium but a dynamic condition requiring continuous relational maintenance, a demand that grows more exacting as the community deepens its affective investment.

From Taobao Live to the Maker Festival to the Golden Taobao Awards, this is a progressive path that extends from the co-creation of the consumption experience, through the co-creation of product innovation, and ultimately to the co-creation of community identity. It delineates Taobao's strategic evolution from a transactional two-sided marketplace into a multi-layered co-creation ecosystem. This trajectory demonstrates that for digital platforms, the meaning of open innovation has long since extended beyond the external sourcing of knowledge for product development to encompass the co-production of the very social relations and cultural foundations upon which the platform ecosystem depends. Yet each layer simultaneously generates its own distinctive dilemma: the empowerment of content creators alongside the concentration of power in livestreaming, the celebration of creative merchants alongside the exclusion of commodity sellers in the Maker Festival, and the cultivation of elite community solidarity alongside peripheral alienation in the Golden Taobao Awards. These tensions are not anomalous side-effects of Taobao's co-creation strategy but its constitutive contradictions—contradictions whose management will determine whether the platform's co-creative ecosystem proves resilient or fractures along the very lines its own practices have drawn.

Stepping back from the operational tensions already discussed, it is necessary to evaluate Taobao's open co-creation strategy against the counterfactual of remaining a purely transactional marketplace.

The primary strategic gain lies in repositioning the platform's competitive ground. As a purely search-driven marketplace, Taobao competed on assortment breadth and price efficiency which increasingly be vulnerable to Pinduoduo's social commerce model and Douyin's content-driven consumption. The co-creation strategy shifted competition onto a fundamentally different terrain defined by experiential richness and ecosystem stickiness. Livestreaming commerce, the Maker Festival, and the Golden Taobao Awards are not mere feature additions, instead they constitute an entirely new value proposition that competitors cannot readily replicate through price wars or infrastructure investment. This effectively changed the terms of competition, forcing rivals to compete on ground Taobao itself had defined rather than inherited. A secondary gain is that co-creation deepened ecosystem lock-in beyond what transactional efficiency can achieve. A merchant making a pure traffic arbitrage calculation may shift platforms for marginally better economics. A merchant who has built a livestream following, participated in the Maker Festival, or been inducted into the Golden Taobao Awards community has accumulated platform-specific social capital and identity investments whose value would be destroyed by departure, transforming the competition from based on efficiency to based on accumulated relational assets that are difficult to replicate (Cusumano, Gawer & Yoffie, 2019). However, structural costs inseparable from the co-creation model itself are shadowed by these gains. A transactional marketplace maintains arm's-length relationships with participants which means any individual merchant can depart without systemic consequence. Contradictory, a co-creation ecosystem develops deep interdependencies with specific, identifiable actors such as top streamers, celebrated maker-merchants, award-winning brands whose decisions and reputations become material variables in platform performance. Therefore, the platform cannot unilaterally dictate terms to partners upon whom its value proposition depends, entering a condition of mutual hostage rather than unilateral control. A further cost is the progressive dilution of the platform's value proposition. Transactional marketplace

has a communicable identity through connecting buyers and sellers efficiently. Instead, co-creation ecosystem is simultaneously a shopping destination, entertainment platform, community hub, innovation laboratory and ritual space. This multiplicity creates genuine tensions, consumers seeking quick purchases must navigate a landscape cluttered with content while merchants find success increasingly demands competencies in content creation and community management tangential to their core business. The strategic evolution toward co-creation, while generative of new value, progressively blurs the clarity of the original proposition. In summary, the trajectory illuminated here is that the movement from transaction facilitation to ecosystem co-creation is not a one-way path to competitive superiority but a transformation that exchanges one set of strategic vulnerabilities for another. Taobao should endure the challenge lying in managing the tension between the two.

This essay has traced Taobao's strategic trajectory from a transactional two-sided marketplace toward a multi-layered co-creation ecosystem. The analysis demonstrates that this transformation was catalyzed by converging pressures including external competition, the inherent shallowness of transactional relationships, and evolving consumer expectations, and unfolded across three increasingly deep layers of stakeholder collaboration. Taobao Live co-produced the consumption experience itself; the Maker Festival extended co-creation into product innovation; and the Golden Taobao Awards elevated it to the cultural construction of community identity. Each layer, however, generated its own distinctive dilemmas: power concentration among top streamers, creative exclusion of ordinary merchants, and the fragility of identity-based governance. Therefore, the strategic calculus reveals a fundamental trade-off: the platform exchanged the vulnerabilities of a transactional marketplace, namely price competition and weak user loyalty, for the vulnerabilities of a co-creation ecosystem, namely partner dependency, identity dilution, and affective volatility. The broader implication for platform studies is that open innovation goes

beyond idea sourcing to the very production of social and cultural foundations, and that the governance of co-creation, rather than its initiation, is the enduring strategic challenge.

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